

Structure Function and Purpose: General Structures of Texts

They Say, I Say

This transition essentially just indicates that the second half of the text **contrasts** with the first half. This is especially true when the first half indicates a belief either commonly held or previously held by scholars/scientists and the second half indicates a new study that challenges the previous viewpoint. The central idea for this structure will always be in the new information.

Ex.

In ancient Greece, conventional wisdom held that motion was a principle of life only. As a consequence of this metaphysical presupposition, philosophers believed that the stars and planets must have, themselves, been alive considering that they very clearly possessed a kind of heavenly motion. They also attributed the status of gods with personalities to these astral bodies. Since then, astrophysicists and mathematicians have uncovered that these astral bodies move due to a set of complex physical laws that affect non-living things as well. Sir Isaac Newton's discovery of gravity, in particular, helped astronomers revise the prejudices of ancient societies.

Ex.

Political scientists have long believed that the most effective route to winning a presidential election involves a candidate spreading his or her time equally across all states in order to maximize the reach of their political claim. This approach makes intuitive sense since diverging from it could cause some states to feel neglected by that candidate. However, researchers John Doe and Jane Doe have recently begun to challenge this notion. Instead, they assert that candidates who strategically spend more time campaigning in states with more voters who are likely to change their mind are much more likely to win elections.

General Claim and Example

The main idea will always be about the general claim. The example only exists to grant support to the claim (just like in rhetorical synthesis questions!). There are two kinds: (1) a simple general claim while the rest of the text explains a single example, and (2) a scientific/scholarly claim while the rest of the text offers a research study corroborating that claim.

Ex.

Not all cases of interspecies breeding – sexual reproduction that takes place between two different species – lead to the production infertile offspring, as it does in the case of the mule. The scalloped hammerhead (*Sphyrna Lewini*) and the Carolina hammerhead (*Sphyrna Gilberti*) are genetically distinct and geographically isolated enough to be considered different species. Despite this, they have been known to occasionally encroach on each other's territories and engage in sexual reproduction, and their offspring are capable of reproducing themselves.

Ex.

Despite centuries of research under the present scientific method, the discovery of new organs in the human body are still being made. In 2018, researchers Jane Doe and colleagues discovered what they have termed the “interstitium”. The interstitium is a contiguous fluid-filled space existing between a structural barrier, such as a cell membrane or the skin, and internal structures, such as organs, including muscles and the circulatory system. This discovery has led to a new understanding of the transportation of nutrients, fluids, and signalling molecules across the various membranes of the human body.